

whipped and will not fight.” Shocked into silence, Davis unwillingly gave Johnston permission to put out peace feelers to Sherman.

In the meeting that followed—held on April 17, in a log cabin near Durham Station—Sherman initially went beyond his remit from Washington. He held out to Johnston the prospect of the readmission of Southern states to the Union on terms of full citizenship with no threat of persecution for treason or war crimes. In doing so, he strayed into political rather than purely military territory. He was subsequently reprimanded by the authorities in Washington and General Ulysses S. Grant was sent to take over the negotiations. Grant made it clear that while the military terms offered at Appomattox still stood and applied to Johnston’s army as well as Lee’s, there could be no bargaining on the larger postwar settlement.

Johnston surrenders

When Davis was informed of Grant’s conditions, he was eager to fight on. Johnston’s reply was scathing. “We have to save the people, spare the blood of the army, and save the high civic functionaries,” he told the Confederate president. He added that “your plan, I think, can do only the last.” The next day, April 26, Johnston agreed to surrender the forces under his command, including Confederate troops in Georgia, Florida, and the Carolinas, a total of almost 90,000 men.

In Alabama, the Confederate commander, General Richard Taylor, watched developments to the north with fatalistic gloom. Like Johnston, he had been fighting a losing battle, in his case against two separate Union forces in the north and south of the state. As soon as he heard of Johnston’s negotiations with Sherman, he too sued for peace. On May 8 at Citronelle, Alabama, he agreed with General Edward Canby, the Union commander-in-chief in the state, to accept terms similar to those that had been offered to Lee and Johnston. By that time only one Confederate army was still officially at war with the Union: that of the vast Trans-Mississippi Department, under the command of General Edmund Kirby Smith.